Super Soprano

Shreya Ghoshal, 39
Singer



WHAT WOMEN SHOULD DO "Don't give in to norms and fear that *ye hi karna zaroori hai, tabhi jaake hoga* [If I do this, then only will it happen]. Pursue your dreams with your self-respect intact"

THE BIG ENABLER **Sanjay Leela Bhansali. "I feel blessed that I have a director who goes by his vision and not by numbers or what the label will say"**

MOST KIDS GROW UP ON LULLABIES. Shreya Ghoshal, on the other hand, had her mother Sarmishta's sonorous renditions of Rabindra Sangeet and classical compositions played on the harmonium reverberate in her ears. "I'd be in her lap and fall asleep," recalls Ghoshal. "She has been the most instrumental to my music." Not just her mother but also Shreya's nuclear scientist father, Bishwajit, would support her talent, building her an electronic tanpura long before it became available in the market and buying mixtapes of popular Hindi film songs to inspire her. When her friends were busy playing, Shreya spent hours exercising her vocal cords. "I never felt I lost my childhood. I spent my time and energy doing what gave me ultimate joy." It wasn't long before the family packed their bags from Rawatbhata in Rajasthan to let Shreya hit all the right notes in Mumbai. She was 13.

There's been no looking back since. Ghoshal's breakthrough came at 16 when she won the inaugural season of the reality TV show *Sa Re Ga Ma Pa*. Filmmaker Sanjay Leela Bhansali would notice her talent and give her a dream maiden gig with *Devdas* (2002); she'd subsequently win the National Award for *'Bairi Piya'*. Multiple awards across languages have followed in her 21-year-long musical journey, but Shreya admits that it does feel a tad lonely at the top. The Hindi film music industry continues to be a male-dominated bastion. She speaks of how rare it is to see women in the recording studio—be it sound engineers or arrangers. The paucity of women in the credits of a song and on year-ending charts highlights the gender disparity.

ACCOMPLISHMENT
The rare female artist who gets solo chartbusters in different languages and consistently features in year-end top 10 lists of India's most streamed artists

"I'm blessed that the industry has been kind to me, for I've had the most amazing collaborations. But I do feel that it's not going in a progressive manner when it comes to film music," says Shreya. The current era, she notes, is in sharp contrast to the wonder years of Lata Mangeshkar and Asha Bhonsle. The scene isn't any different in independent music. Says Shreya, "How many solo songs do women get? Sometimes films are women-centric yet, there's a male voice... I have to fight for lines even now. I insist my lines come in the *mukhda*. If they bring me in the *antara*, then I don't sing it. Not everyone is OK with it. But I have to calculate my demands too and make my choices accordingly."

For Shreya, it's all part of fighting the good fight. "If I'm making myself heard to the composer, the filmmaker or the label, it is getting registered," she says. "[Hope is] that it probably paves the path for the next generation of female singers. I feel a better day is coming." With a voice as impactful as hers the change will certainly come. ■

–Suhani Singh

Photographs by MILIND SHELTE